

54 Hydrae
7 SunsR Hydrae
37 SunsPi Hydrae
42 Suns

HYDRA

THE WATER SNAKE

THE LARGEST OF ALL CONSTELLATIONS, HYDRA REPRESENTS A MONSTER SLAIN BY THE GREEK HERO HERCULES. THE SIX STARS MARKING THE SERPENT'S HEAD ARE THE EASIEST TO PICK OUT.

Although the monster confronted by Hercules in the ancient Greek myths had nine heads, Hydra is depicted in the sky with just a single head. The stars depicting the head are in the northern celestial hemisphere, to the south of Cancer, while most of the body and tail are in the southern celestial hemisphere.

The constellation's brightest star, Alphard, marks the monster's heart. It sits in an otherwise empty looking patch of sky and derives its common name from the Arabic for "the solitary one." The two main objects to look out for in Hydra are the spiral galaxy M83 and the planetary nebula NGC 3242.

The **largest** of the 88 constellations, Hydra stretches more than a **quarter** of the way around the sky

KEY DATA

Size ranking 1
Brightest stars Alphard (α) 2.0, Gamma (γ) 3.0
Genitive Hydrae
Abbreviation Hya
Highest in sky at 10pm February–June
Fully visible 54°N–83°S



CHART 5

MAIN STARS

Alphard Alpha (α) Hydrae
Orange giant

2.0 180 light-years

Gamma (γ) Hydrae
Yellow giant

3.0 145 light-years

Epsilon (ϵ) Hydrae
Quad star system

3.4 130 light-years

R Hydrae
Mira-type variable

5.0 405 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

M68
Globular cluster

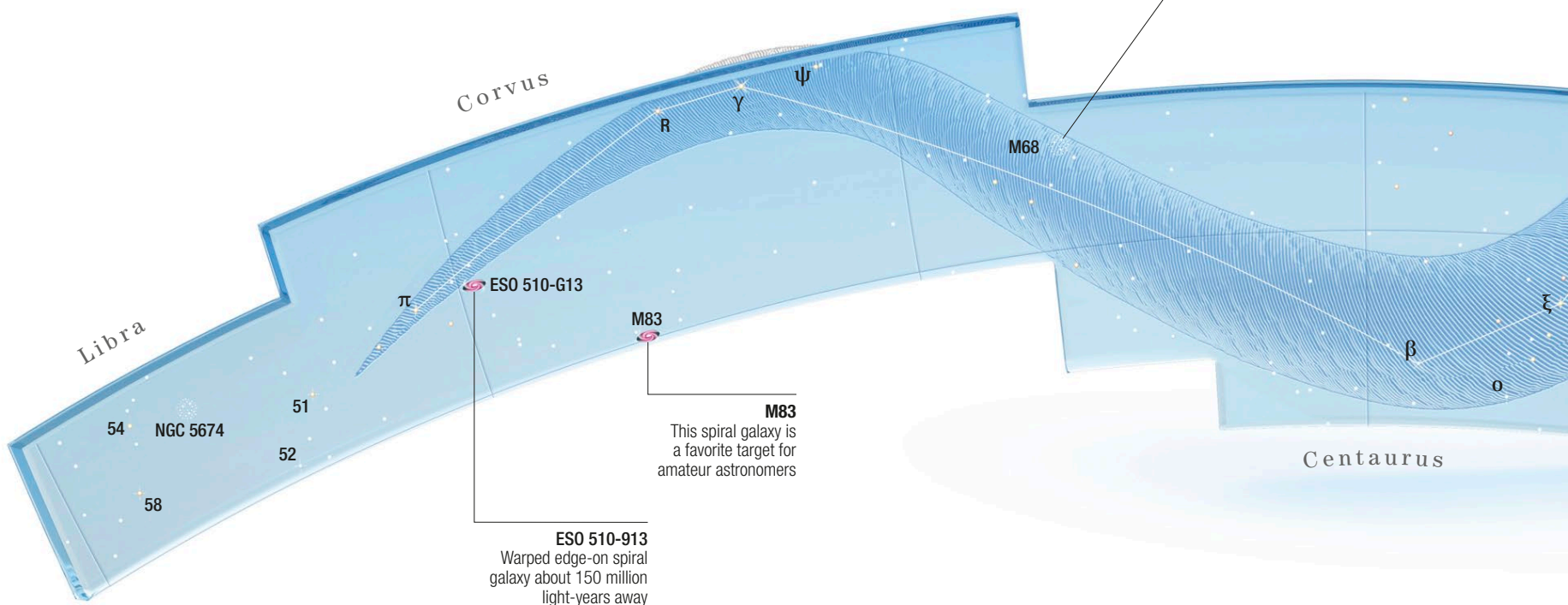
M83 (Southern Pinwheel)
Spiral galaxy

NGC 3242 (Ghost of Jupiter)
Planetary nebula, sometimes also called the Eye Nebula



△ M83

Also known as the Southern Pinwheel, this spiral galaxy is similar in structure to the Milky Way but is a far more active area of star formation and death. The blue and magenta areas are sites of star birth. Also visible in this image are many supernova remnants, as well as thousands of star clusters and hundreds of thousands of individual stars.



M68

The globular cluster M68 looks like a blurred star when seen with binoculars or a small telescope

M83

This spiral galaxy is a favorite target for amateur astronomers

ESO 510-913

Warped edge-on spiral galaxy about 150 million light-years away